

A TEMPTATION OR A TEST?

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The story of the temptation of Jesus has a very a strange setting. A baptismal service is underway in the Jordan River, and an odd-looking minister named John the Baptist is performing the ordinance. John is not cut from the cloth of normal priestly protocol. Quite the contrary: his message is repentance; his attire is a camel-skin suit held up by a leather girdle. His diet is shocking, too: grasshoppers and wild honey highlight the menu. Alas, John is the Grizzly Adams of the religious right, a fashion disaster with a diet never copied.

Even so, a phenomenon unlike anything witnessed by the current religious leaders is taking place. Despite his unorthodox habits and straight-to-the-point sermons, great multitudes follow his ministry. The impact of these all-day repentance and baptismal services in Northern Israel will be felt for more than two thousand years.

Immediately following the baptism of one candidate, John looked up to see a young man approaching at a distance. As the man drew nearer, John recognized the familiar stride of his cousin, Jesus. Exchanging pleasantries with Jesus, John uttered words that would become a prophetic benchmark: *"Behold the lamb of God which taketh away the sins of the world."* Everyone in the crowd caught their breaths! The statement was shocking, even for John! Every Jew was well versed in the work of the sacrificial lamb on the Day of Atonement. But John's bold comment not only declared Jesus to be a lamb, but *"the Lamb of God"* that would "take away the sins of the world." John was clearly saying Jesus was a sacrificial lamb who would attain a threshold of achievement no other lamb had ever attained, though millions had been killed.

After an announcement so remarkable, we might expect Jesus to begin a ministry capable of touching the entire earth. Yet, true to His unconventional pattern, He does nothing of the sort. In fact, His first act seems to downplay the announcement: He asks to be baptized by this rugged wilderness preacher.

Once baptized, a wonderful phenomenon takes place. A beautiful dove defies its nature to make physical contact with a human being. It ascends upon Jesus! Then, a voice resounds

from the sky, saying *"This is my beloved son in whom I am well pleased."* The man John called the Lamb of God was proclaimed by heaven as God's son!

Another amazing event followed immediately. Jesus was *"led of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil."* Rather than maximize the moment, strike while the iron is hot, capitalize on the occasion, Jesus went into seclusion!

The picture becomes extremely vague over the next forty days, but we know Jesus passed the time fasting and praying, and in fellowship with the Father. Jesus emerged from the wilderness to be confronted by Satan himself. Those events are commonly called the "temptation of Jesus."

THE DIFFERENCE BETWEEN TEMPTATION AND TESTING

The "temptation" of Jesus is better described as the "testing" of Jesus. A closer look at these two words reveals a Scriptural truth that has been almost totally ignored. Temptation is self inflicted. "Each one is tempted when he is drawn away by his own desires and enticed" (James 1:14). Testing is allowed by our Heavenly Father for the purpose of:

- Strengthening us,
- Building our faith,
- Preparing us for greatness, and
- Developing character that can stand the onslaught of success and failure.

Conversely, temptation:

- Entices us to do evil,
- Seeks to erode, even terminate, our influence,
- Aims to separate us from close fellowship with God, and
- Seeks to destroy the destiny God has purposed for us.

The testing of Jesus had nothing to do with a moral lapse, but had everything to do with the lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life (see 1 John 2:15-17). The lust of the flesh, the lust of the eyes, and the pride of life appeal to the three-part composition of man: body, soul and spirit.

Follow the wilderness scene in Matthew 4 as testing touched these aspects of the Lord's life:

- *The lust of the flesh.* Jesus had not received nourishment in forty days when the enemy tried to entice Him to satisfy His hunger supernaturally. Was He hungry? He was starving! By appealing to the Lord's need for food in this moment of weakness, Satan

desired Him to act in the power and sovereignty as Son of God, not Son of Man, thereby eliminating Jesus as our great example.

- *The lust of the eyes.* Satan then took Jesus to the pinnacle of the Temple and tried to entice Jesus to prove He was the Son of God by casting Himself down. But, to use divine power and prerogative to defy natural and divine law would sabotage God's plan. Jesus refused. A propensity to the sensual can never satisfy the appetite of the eye. All attempts to satisfy the soul leave the individual lusting for more.
- *The pride of life.* Satan continued the test by appealing to the spiritual side of Jesus. He led Jesus to a high mountain, telling Him if He would bow down and worship, Satan would reward Him with all He could see. The spiritual side of every person is destined to rule as a king and priest. We can get ourselves into trouble if we worship the wrong things and try to reign over territory we are not given. Because we have a predisposition for worshipping and reigning, many of our tests will be spiritual in nature.

THE VULNERABILITY OF TEMPTATION

(James 1:12-15)

There are three basic temptations or tests we all face. First, *we are tested by things God allows*. This testing has its limits because God has evaluated our spiritual character which has been pre-determined as sufficient for the test. I see no record in Scripture of anyone failing a test that was pre-approved by God.

Second, *we are tempted by the enemy*. God will never sanction a temptation that allows for a moral failure. The enemy cannot force you to sin; the devil did not make you do it! He can do no more than make a brief presentation of the temptation. We are tempted by self-inflicted temptation. By our own volition and imagination, we take the bait of Satan and imagine our way into a situation we are powerless to win.

Look at the life of Samson: He was the son of Manoah. An Angel announced his birth. He was to be a Nazarite. He was to be a deliverer for Israel. The Spirit of the Lord moved upon him from time to time, allowing him to accomplish heroic feats. He met Delilah and eventually told her the secret of his success. She sold him out; he lost his power with God. He was blinded and made a circus attraction. Eventually, through repentance, his strength was restored.

Third, *temptation has to do with an enticement to do what is in direct moral conflict with Biblical standards and practices*. According to James 1:13-15, God cannot be tempted by these

things and will not authorize such an attack against us! Any enticement to do what is not morally convenient is not from God, but from Satan himself. If the attack carries these illegal components, it is a “covert” attack and must be dealt with as such. In fighting against such an attack, we should use all the weapons at our disposal. We must stand firm, quoting Scriptures, as Jesus did. We must “throw the book” (the Bible) at the devil! This kind of attack is normally won or lost at the point of impact. If we entertain temptation, if we do not resist it the moment it enters our mind, usually we lose the fight.

Almost unknowingly, many Christians willingly place themselves in vulnerable positions. Others fail to implement a “search and destroy” mentality during the initial impact. Either way we become vulnerable to an enemy who is merciless once he has penetrated our defenses!

THE PROTECTION OF TESTING

You are probably thinking that Jesus faced the same temptations we do, yet He did not sin. This is true; the Bible states it very vigorously in Hebrews 4:15.

So what kind of temptation did Jesus face?

- *He was restricted by the limitations of the flesh.* He became hungry. In Matthew 4, this was the first way the enemy tested Him.
- *He became physically exhausted.* Several times in Scripture, He removed Himself from the crowd for rest and relaxation.
- *He became lonely.* "Foxes have holes, birds have nests, but the son of man does not have a place to lay His head."
- *He suffered rejection.* The betrayal by Judas must have saddened the Son of God. The night prior to the crucifixion, as Jesus agonized in prayer, His disciples could not stay awake with Him for one hour. We can almost hear the rejection in Jesus' voice as He says, "Sleep on now."
- *He endured conflict within His family.* Do you think Mary and Joseph were happy when He went missing for three days? (People want to know where Jesus was between ages 12 and 30. I think Mary grounded him for disappearing without permission! ☺)

- *He was tempted to get angry* and lose His temper, as exemplified by the way He dealt with moneychangers in the Temple.
- *He suffered physical pain* (the crucifixion).

Though Jesus was tested in many ways, there is no evidence in the Bible that He was tempted to do anything in conflict with Biblical standards or practices! Did the idea of doing any such thing ever enter His mind? Perhaps, but He knew the power of casting imaginations down upon impact.

This is where our battle with the devil is won or lost. If we allow the mental process to go beyond an initial thought, we have stepped outside the protection God has so graciously provided. When we allow ourselves to step outside His protection and provision, we are no match for the devil. If we will cast down every thought of immorality and unscriptural practices upon impact, we will never cave into the temptation to do these things!

Every test we face must meet the approval of God in advance. God looks at the test and then looks at where we are in our development and what we are capable of enduring in the physical, emotional and spiritual realm. He considers our faith and endurance. He will never allow the enemy to bring something against us we are incapable of handling.

Testing has to do with living in right relationship with God and others, regardless of the pressure to do otherwise. Testing also has to do with standing on the promises of God. To the person who is tested by God, the highest form of reality is what the Word of God has to say on the subject.

Here's the bottom line: Temptation has everything to do with our own lusts and appetites; tests have to do with our personal development and spiritual maturity. When we are working our way through a test, rather than a temptation, the sounds, sights and smell of victory are never beyond our reach!

The key to success in any test we face is to live within the hedge of protection God has provided for us and never allow the devil to entice us to step outside the Bloodline!

